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FEED THE DUCKS

A strategy board game for 2 to 4 players
by **Néstor Romeral Andrés**

CONCEPT

Three old men and a small child all sit around a small duck pond, tossing breadcrumbs into the water. With each ripple from a crumb, ducks race toward the new treat. (They never actually get the snack, due to the wily fish just below the surface, but it doesn't dissuade them from trying!) Passersby watch the scene for a moment, then smile, charmed by these four people idling away their time. Little do they realize that these crafty individuals actually have a standing wager: Each has chosen a color of duck in the pond as his own, and whoever can gather his ducks into a group first gets to choose the adventure for the day!

INTRODUCTION

Feed the ducks is a board game for two to four players. Each game lasts about 20 minutes. Players drop breadcrumbs into the pond, in order to attract the ducks. There are ducks in 4 colors. The first player to coerce all the ducks of his color into a single group wins.

The basic set includes components for a 2-player game. In order to play 3- or 4-player games you need the additional ducks and counters (red and blue).

MATERIAL

This is what you need in order to play **Feed the ducks**:

- A board depicting a pond with 61 hexagonal spaces.

- 12 white ducks, 12 black ducks (plus 8 red ducks and 6 blue ducks optionally).



- A breadcrumb (not included)

- One white counter, one black counter (plus one red counter and one blue counter optionally).

- A carrying case.

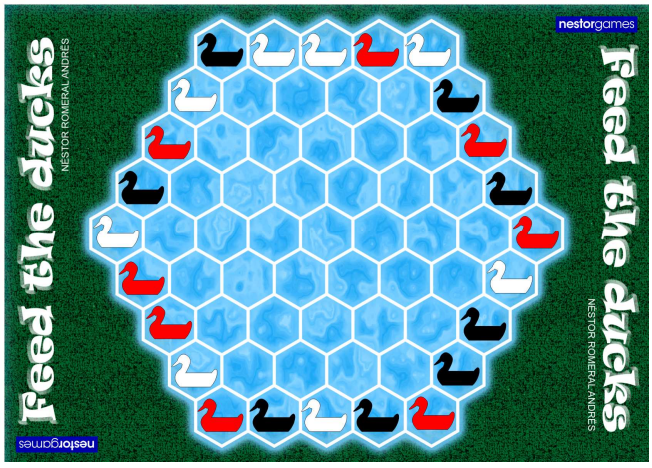
GAME PREPARATION

Each player chooses a player color and takes the corresponding counter; the counters just show which player is which color. Also put the appropriate number of ducks of each player color in the pond, as indicated in this table:

Players	Ducks per player
2	12
3	8
4	6

To set up the pond, fill the outer edge of the pond (one duck per space): Starting with White, players take turns counterclockwise placing any duck on an edge space of the pond.

Variant: Just place the ducks randomly, but be sure there are no more than 2 ducks of the same color grouped together.



Example of 3-player setup

Take a breadcrumb and place it next to the board.

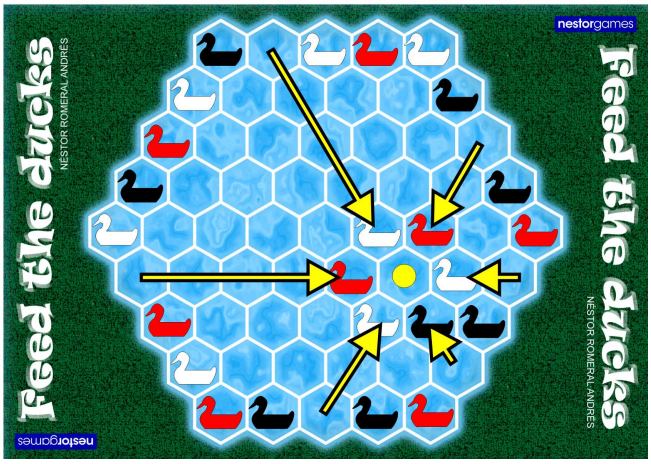
The game can start now. White plays first.

GAME RULES

The game is played in turns, counterclockwise. White starts by placing the breadcrumb on any empty space on the board.

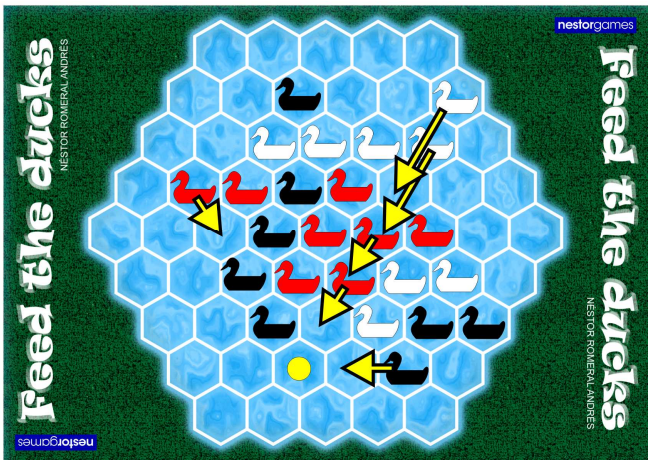
Now, any and every duck in the six lines radiating out from the breadcrumb move straight toward the breadcrumb as far as they can. There will never be more than one duck in a space, and the ducks stop just before they reach the breadcrumb (a fish gets it first).

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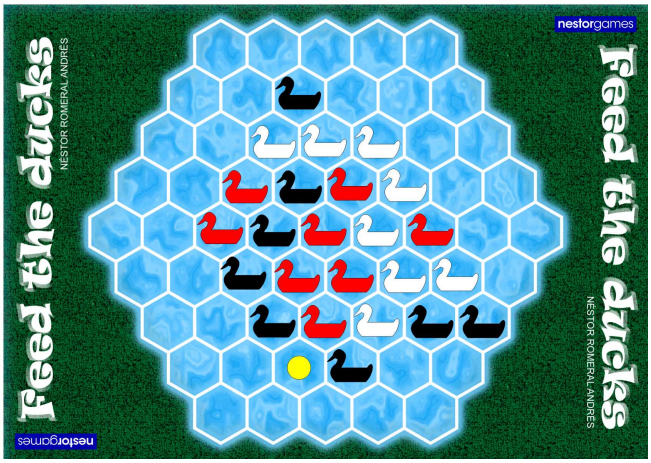


Duck movement

Notice that every duck in the 6 directions must be moved:



Example: 6 ducks must move toward the breadcrumb



End of movement

Then the turn passes to the next player.

From now on, on your turn, you **must** take the breadcrumb and place it on an empty space of the board that is not on any of the six lines radiating from the breadcrumb's previous location…

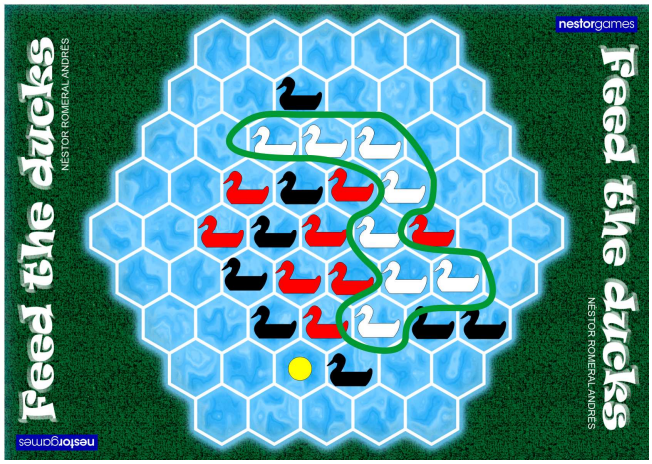


Illegal breadcrumb placements, due to its current location

… and then move the ducks toward the breadcrumb as usual.

GAME END

For a 2 or 4 player game, the game ends when all the ducks of one color have gathered into a single connected group. For a 3-player game, the game ends when at least 7 ducks of one color have gathered into a single group (all but one). The player of the corresponding color wins the game. In case of several winning groups are created simultaneously, the player who placed the game-ending breadcrumb chooses the winner from the tied players.



Example: White wins

ADVANCED VARIANT FOR 3-PLAYER GAMES

The game ends when all 8 ducks of one color have gathered into a single group, instead of 7.

NOTES FROM THE DESIGNER

The average number of turns is around 20. During the first games it might look like the game won't end, but it always does. Nice, isn't it?

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